Challenge Stigma / Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #4

Anger and Short Fuse Days

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Anger is often a stress signal. Catch it at yellow, not red.

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Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. What Short-Fuse Days Really Mean

Anger is usually the visible layer of a deeper load stack: fatigue, pain, threat activation, and unresolved stress.

When you are overloaded, the gap between trigger and reaction shrinks. Small events get treated like major threats.

Early warning signs

- Jaw clench, shoulder tension, or heat rise
- Faster speech and sharper tone
- All-or-nothing thinking
- Urge to dominate, shut down, or leave hard

2. Why Anger Spikes on Certain Days

- Sleep debt and back-to-back shifts
- Hunger, dehydration, and pain load
- Compounded stress with no discharge
- Unrepaired conflict from earlier in week

> *Why this works: early interoceptive cue awareness increases inhibitory control and reduces aggressive outbursts.*

3. The 90-Second Anger Interrupt

1. **Name your state:** say, 'I am loading up.'
2. **Move your body:** walk, wall push, or cold-water reset to burn activation.
3. **Lengthen exhale:** 4-in, 6-out for five cycles.
4. **Delay verbal response:** buy 90 seconds before speaking on charged topics.

4. Repair After Anger Leakage

- Own behavior without excuses.
- Name the impact on the other person.
- State one specific behavior you will change.
- Follow through within 24 hours.

> Repair sentence template: 'I came in too hot. That was not okay. Next time I will call yellow and reset before speaking.'

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5. When Anger Requires Additional Care

- Verbal intimidation or property damage
- Family fear and avoidance patterns
- Escalating alcohol or drug use tied to anger
- Frequent remorse with no sustained behavior change

6. 7-Day Fuse-Length Drill

Each day log one trigger, one early cue, and whether you used the 90-second interrupt before saying something you regret.

> **Daily target:**
> One early cue catch.
> One reset before reaction.
> One repair if needed.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Anger and Short-Fuse Days - Fuse Tracker

Track anger patterns and practice interrupting escalation before red-zone behavior.

What triggered your anger spikes this week?

List event, context, and load factors (sleep, hunger, pain, stress).

What did anger cost you?

Include impact on trust, connection, decisions, and self-respect.

What interrupt will you use this week?

Choose one script + one body reset to run consistently.

1. First warning cue:

What signal told you your fuse was shortening?

2. Interrupt used:

What did you do in the first 90 seconds?

3. Outcome:

Did intensity drop or continue rising?

4. Repair action:

If anger leaked, what specific repair did you complete?

> Progress is measured by fewer red events and faster repairs.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Anger and Short-Fuse Days - Repair Plan

Use this with partner/family to make post-anger repair specific and consistent.

What anger behaviors cause most damage?

List the top two behaviors to eliminate first.

What repair does each person need?

Ask directly and write it plainly.

What is your no-excuses repair protocol?

Define timing, wording, and behavior follow-through.

1. First repair sentence:

Write the exact words you will use.

2. Behavior-change commitment:

What concrete behavior changes this week?

3. Follow-up check date:

When will you verify that repair landed?

> Trust returns faster when repair is specific and repeated.

Closing

Anger is information. It tells you your system is loaded and your safety margin is thin.
The goal is not to never feel anger. The goal is to act skillfully before anger causes damage.

About the Author

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Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.